Emotional Intelligence in Practice - Study guide

Practitioner course | Trainer: Maya Thompson

About this guide

Use emotional intelligence in real conversations: feedback, conflict and influence.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Stay steady in a heated conversation

- Give feedback that lands without defensiveness

- Influence peers without positional power

Emotions in everyday decisions

- Emotion is data, not noise

- Unnoticed feelings steer decisions

- Name it, then decide

Welcome to Emotional Intelligence in Practice. This course assumes you know the basics, and focuses on using them in real situations: decisions, feedback and conflict. We start with the idea that emotions are data, not noise. A feeling of unease before a meeting may be pointing at something real. A feeling of excitement may be clouding your judgement. Unnoticed feelings steer decisions quietly. When you notice and name them, you can take them into account without letting them take over.

Reading your emotional signals

- Notice the body first

- Ask what the feeling is about

- Decide whether it helps this decision

Emotions often show up in the body before the mind. A tight chest, a clenched jaw, a knot in the stomach. Learn your own early signals. When you feel one, ask what it is about. Is it the situation, the person, or something older that the situation reminds you of. Then ask whether the feeling helps with the decision in front of you.

Sometimes it does, for instance caution before a risky move. Sometimes it does not, such as irritation about something unrelated. Sorting the two is a skill that improves with use.

Staying steady in a heated conversation

- Slow your breathing and your pace

- Name the emotion in the room

- Return to the shared goal

When a conversation heats up, the first job is to steady yourself. Slow your breathing and slow your speech, because your pace sets the pace for everyone. If the emotion is obvious, name it calmly, for example, I can see this matters a lot to both of us. Then return to the shared goal, which is usually a good result for the team or the customer. Avoid arguing about who is right. The aim is not to win the point, it is to reach a solution you can both live with, while keeping the relationship intact.

Feedback without the sting

- Be specific about the behaviour

- Describe the impact, not the character

- Invite their view

Feedback often triggers defensiveness because it feels like a judgement of the person. To reduce that, describe the specific behaviour, not a trait. Say, in the last two meetings you interrupted before others finished, not, you are rude. Describe the impact, for example, the team has stopped sharing ideas. Then invite their view, since they may have context you lack. Defensiveness drops when people feel heard. If you are receiving feedback, listen fully first, thank the person, and take time before responding if you need it.

Working through conflict

- Make both sides feel heard

- Separate interests from positions

- Agree a next step

Conflict is normal in any team that cares about its work. The first goal is to make both sides feel heard, which often reduces the heat by itself. Next, separate positions from interests. A position is what someone says they want. An interest is why they want it. Two people may disagree on the position but share the interest, such as a smooth launch. Once interests are on the table, options appear. Finish by agreeing a concrete next step, and a time to check whether it worked.

Influencing without authority

- Understand what the other person cares about

- Make a clear, specific request

- Build trust before you need it

Much of working life involves influencing people who do not report to you. Start by understanding what they care about, and connect your request to it. Make the request clear and specific, including what you need, by when, and why. And build trust before you need it, by being reliable and helping others when you can. People are far more willing to support someone they trust. Avoid pressure tactics, which may work once, but damage the relationship. Respect and clarity are slower, but they last.

Putting it into practice

- Choose one conversation you have been avoiding

- Prepare the opening and the goal

- Review how it went afterwards

The way to build these skills is to use them on real conversations. Choose one you have been avoiding. Prepare how you will open, what the shared goal is, and what you will do if the other person becomes upset. Have the conversation, then review. What went well, what would you change, what did you learn about the other person. Writing a few lines straight afterwards makes the learning stick. Each conversation makes the next one easier, and over a few months the change in how you handle difficult moments becomes clear.

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Your next steps

- Pick one conversation to have this week

- Use the feedback structure

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, pick one conversation you will have this week and write down your opening. Use the feedback structure from this lecture. Complete the workbook for this course, which has a conflict planning sheet and a feedback template. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson, you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you worked through the course. Thank you for your time, and good luck with the conversations ahead.

Glossary

Position: What someone says they want in a disagreement.

Interest: The reason behind a position, which often overlaps with what the other side wants.

Defensiveness: A protective reaction to perceived criticism that makes listening harder.

Influence: Moving a decision or action without relying on formal authority.